

diplomacy

KABUL BLAST

Indo-Pak dialogue may be hit, as Afghanistan alleges ISI hand behind Kabul blast and India cancels security talks

■ By Saurabh Shukla

Barely a month after India and Pakistan gave a green signal to the next round of the composite dialogue process and it seemed that under a civilian regime in Pakistan, the stalled dialogue process would chug and the bilateral relationship would grow, the honeymoon seems to be over between the two neighbours.

In what was perhaps the strongest public indictment of Pakistan by India, National Security Adviser M.K. Narayanan blamed Pakistan's intelligence agency ISI for masterminding the Kabul attack on July 7, which killed 54 people, including two senior Indian diplomats. Narayanan was also joined by Afghanistan's President Hamid Karzai, who blamed Islamabad for the attack. "We have told the Government of Pakistan that the killings of people in Afghanistan are carried out by Pakistan's intelligence and its military departments," Karzai said. "We know who martyred the people a few days back in Kabul," he said, referring to the attack on the Indian Embassy.

Coming at a time when the UPA Government is neck deep in tackling the trust vote in Parliament on July 22, New Delhi cancelled a scheduled trip of CBI Director Vijay Shankar to Pakistan to hold talks on security cooperation in an indication of the growing chill in the relationship. "There was no point having talks with Pakistan on security cooperation when their agencies are executing terrorist attacks. So we asked the CBI director not to go for the talks, which sent out a strong message to Pakistan," says a senior official in the South Block. Now, the foreign office is contemplating if taking forward the proposed joint secretary-level talks under the composite dialogue process, followed by the visit of the Pakistani foreign secretary to New Delhi on July 21, would serve any purpose.

India has limited its options, following Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's assertion that the dialogue process was irreversible and that Pakistan was itself

a victim of terrorism, which may be used by Islamabad to put pressure on India to continue the talks. For India, which has consciously tried hard to develop a friendly relationship with Pakistan and had recently restarted its back-channel diplomacy with it on key issues like Kashmir, the attack comes as a huge setback. Sources say during the visit of Indian Foreign Secretary Shiv Shankar Menon to Kabul last week, Afghan officials told him that Kabul will provide clinching evidence to prove Pakistani hand in the attack. However, Islamabad denies involvement. On June 23, the Afghan Interior Ministry had informed India's Ambassador Jayant Prasad about a possible suicide attack

on the Indian mission. Now faced with the intelligence reports suggesting that ISI will only ratchet up tensions and there were attempts to target India through third countries, the prospects of a meaningful dialogue look even more remote.

Security agencies have warned that infiltration from across the line of control will go up and the militant attacks may be on the rise in the run up to the Jammu and Kashmir elections. The Pakistani intelligence agency is even believed to have trained top Khalistan leaders in ISI safe houses in Karachi and Lahore in a bid to revive the movement and create communal tension in India. It has also been reportedly sending fake Indian currency into the country.

TROUBLE MAKERS:
Taliban fighters in
Afghanistan



RETURN OF MIS